

Negatives

A NEGATIVE TURNS A POSITIVE STATEMENT INTO A NEGATIVE ONE.

In order to show that something is incorrect or untrue in English, a positive statement has to be turned into a negative one—usually by adding the word *not* after an auxiliary verb. Double negatives should be avoided.

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REAL WORLD

Satisfied?

When British rock band the Rolling Stones sang “I can’t get no satisfaction” in 1965, they canceled the negative *can’t* out with the negative *no*. But despite the double negative, the meaning was clear, and listeners worldwide understood the band to be thoroughly dissatisfied.



Forming negative sentences

Auxiliary verbs are the only verbs that can be made negative. If a sentence does not contain an auxiliary verb, one must be added. The negative word *not* is then placed directly after the auxiliary verb. The resulting combination is known as a negative auxiliary.



Frank **had not been** to a German
believe he **wouldn't** try a curried

Contractions

In negative sentences, the auxiliary verb and the negative word *not* can be combined and shortened to form contractions, with an apostrophe to represent the missing letter or letters. Common negative contractions include *haven't* (have not) and *can't* (cannot).

Auxiliary verb	Negative word	Contraction
would	not	wouldn't
do	not	don't
should	not	shouldn't
could	not	couldn't
will	not	won't

Most negative contractions are formed by joining the two words and removing the *o* from *not*.

There are some exceptions: Here, the *i* from *will* has also been changed to *o*.